

Mountain Heritage Trust

Annual Report 2019



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Enquiries and Acquisitions

Enquiries

In 2019 the Mountain Heritage Trust received 178 enquiries - an increase of 38% on 2018. Enquiries ranged from requests to donate material to MHT (some of which were accepted and some rejected as duplication or not relevant to our collecting areas - see below for acquisitions) and permission to reproduce images from our collections, to requests for work experience, interest in borrowing our education boxes, and a range of people wishing to consult or obtain information from our collections. Some of these we were able to assist with directly, others involved redirecting enquirers to other collections such as those at the Alpine Club and the Royal Geographical Society. We also provided professional support and advice to related organisations including The Pinnacle Club and Mountain Rescue England and Wales.

Acquisitions

In 2019 the Mountain Heritage Trust received 45 separate donations into our collections, remaining at a similar level to 2018.

Additions to the collections included:

- The Don Robinson Collection, a major collection relating to DR Walls, one of the UK's leading climbing wall manufacturers.
- The Chris Craggs Collection, a large collection of slides taken by guidebook illustrator Chris Craggs.
- Research notes relating to Arthur Dolphin.
- Two handwritten new routes books from Wales and the Dove Crag cave visitors book from the 1960s and 1970s.
- Ian McNaught Davis' slide collection.
- The Dr Gordon Lindsay-Jones Collection.
- Additions of slides to the Alan Hankinson Collection.
- A large number of handling collection items which were obtained as the result of a direct appeal to help us fill our education boxes.
- Donations of books and magazines to help fill gaps in our reference collections.

Projects

Resilience Project

Much of the Trustees' time in 2019 was occupied with a National Lottery Heritage Fund funded project to improve the Trust's organisational strength and ongoing resilience. The project was managed by independent consultant Jennie Pitceathly and resulted in the following outcomes for the Trust:

- Two days of reflection and planning for Trustees, led by independent consultant John Atkinson. Follow on communications and ideas were then worked up into a five-year development plan, an executive summary of this plan will be available on our website in early 2020.
- A programme of training for Staff and Trustees ranging from role-specific training such as chair training and governance training, to training designed to promote networking and inspire the future vision of the Trust which included attendance by a Trustee at the Sporting Heritage Conference.
- Investment in the Axiell CALM content management system for MHT's collections. Two members of staff, a Trustee and two volunteers undertook dedicated training of the new system and data migration and population is now well under way. Part of MHT's next major funding bid will include funding for making this information available online.

Man and Mountain Heritage Lottery Fund Project

This Heritage Lottery Fund funded project focusing on the life of Chris Bonington included an exhibition at Keswick Museum, oral history recordings and programme of education events and resource production. It launched in 2017 and all documentation and reporting was completed on 29 April 2019.

Particular thanks are due to: Julie Summers who curated the exhibition in a voluntary capacity; Debbie Watson the Education Officer who went above and beyond the brief she was given to produce some fantastic sessions and resources which remain available for schools to use and borrow; and all the volunteers who helped work on the exhibition (including the substantial installation and de-installation efforts), oral history project and learning materials.

Scaling the Heights exhibition

Featuring photographs, 1970s Action Man figures and original artefacts from significant mountaineering expeditions, the Scaling the Heights exhibition was curated and installed into Keswick Museum by artists Stephen and Margaret Livingstone and Dr Abbie Garrington of

Durham University. It was installed on 13th February and remained in place until the end of December 2019.

Visitor numbers: 14,127

Rangers' Hut conversion and office refurbishment

Thanks to funding received from the Friends of Blencathra, MHT was able to refurbish its office with lockable cabinets and also chairs for the board table. We also converted a small building (previously the Rangers' Hut) for storage of non-heritage material such as exhibition boards and banners.

Boardman and Tasker slide collections rehousing

The 43,000 slides in the Pete Boardman and Joe Tasker collections were rehoused into specialist acid-free slide boxes by MHT's dedicated volunteers. Combined with a stable storage environment, this will give them the best chance of long-term survival. All the slides were given a number which will be used as a reference code when they are catalogued and also makes ad-hoc digitisation much more straightforward for file/original cross-referencing.

MHT are grateful to the Boardman Tasker Trust who funded the purchase of the boxes.

Collections Listing

Extensive box listing work was carried out by staff and volunteers on the George Band and Pete Boardman Collections. This will provide a solid foundation for structured cataloguing in the future.

Collections Planning

As part of the Resilience project (see above) the Collections Manager began the process of developing an integrated Collections Management Plan to include a full range of strategies as well as short and long term plans. These will help MHT to collect, care for and share collections

Promotional and Fundraising Events

22-24 March: Sheffield Adventure Film Festival, Trustees and Staff attended with a stand to share our work with festival attendees.

17-19 May : Keswick Mountain Festival, MHT explored the history of the Old Man of Hoy in the BMC Montane Skills Camp and had second hand books available to purchase.

3 August: Three Rounds, One Spine, One Baby. Ultra runner Jasmine Paris travelled to Cumbria to share her stories and experiences at a fundraising evening for MHT organised and hosted by former Trustee Jeff Ford.

8 September: Terry Tasker (Trustee) and Kelda Roe (Collections Manager) presented at the Mountain Rescue England and Wales (MREW) national conference on the work of MHT and the value that heritage work could bring to MREW and individual teams.

21 September: Terry Tasker (Trustee) and Kelda Roe (Collections Manager) presented to the BMC National Council meeting on the work of MHT.

Royal Geographical Society North West Region collaboration

- 25 July Eugene Rae (Archivist RGS) and Kelda Roe teamed up to share rarely seen treasures from the two collections.
- 22 November John Porter gave a talk providing further insight into the stories explored in his award-winning book One Day as a Tiger.

27 November: Ian Smith (Trustee) presented to the BMC Peak Area meeting about the work of MHT.

Partnership work

Allan Bank

The Chorley and Hopkinson Mountaineering Library is made accessible via the National Trust at Allan Bank. In 2019 preliminary work was carried out ahead of efforts to improve access to climbing literature to a range of audiences:

- Inventory of books in library carried out.
- Extended renegotiation of loan agreement undertaken. As a result, in early 2020 the collection will be moved to a new room at Allan Bank where, in addition to the historic collection (which will remain accessible under supervision), there will also be a direct access handling collection of mountaineering books.

University of Cumbria

- A memoranda of understanding was signed to help both organisations understand how we might work together going forward. It is proposed that to begin with MHT will provide opportunities for work experience/project work to University students and the

possibility of a photographic exhibition on campus in the summer of 2020 will be explored.

- MHT also attended the University's communities' open day in April 2019 where we showcased a number of items from our collections.

Mountain Rescue England and Wales

- Mountain Rescue England and Wales are working on a National Lottery Heritage Fund project which, if successful, MHT will be supporting in a number of areas. The outcome of the bid is due in mid-2020.

Recruitment

Trustees

MHT recruited two new Exhibition and Events Trustees in 2019, Ian Smith and Vicky Wilkinson, who joined their first board meeting in June. Unfortunately in October Vicky decided to step down as a Trustee, we will therefore be recruiting to this post in 2020.

In March David Lanceley stood down as MHT's Treasurer after five years in the role for which MHT are very grateful. The post was widely advertised but we struggled to find a suitable candidate to fill this post. Fortunately, this situation changed and in February 2020 Clare Meehan was recruited to this role. MHT are very grateful to Huw Jones for his work producing financial reports for the Trust during the period the Treasurer role was vacant.

Administrator

In May MHT's Administrator Jonny Dry completed his Masters course and went on to work in film production. We wish him well in this work and hope to stay in touch through his voluntary role as a Director of the BMC. The Trust therefore recruited a new Administrator to provide office support for one day per week. Angela Bewick joined the Trust in August 2019 and has settled in well working alongside the Collections Manager and Volunteers.

Collections Manager

In July Charlotte McCarthy completed her contract as Collections Manager (maternity cover) and went on to a new role as Archivist for Peel L&P Management Ltd in Manchester. In the same month Kelda Roe returned to the post of Collections Manager.